beating', but it was too late: the Mirza had fled the scene.[5] Undeterred, Husain Khan pursued Ibrahim and tracked the Mirza down, wounded and imprisoned in Multan. When they met, Husain Khan may have derived some solace from the fact that Ibrahim made a great show of his disappointment at not having fallen to Husain Khan's sword. At least then, said Ibrahim, he would have been defeated by a fellow Sunni, 'my co-religionist', and not a Shia like 'Husain Quli . . . alien in religion and sect!'[6]

Ethnic and religious allegiances still united and divided Akbar's nobility, as they had when the Uzbeks joined forces against him, or Munim Khan was brought to tears by slurs against the Chagatais, but these fissures and alliances were also beginning to take unpredictable turns. If two Sunnis shaking their heads over the fact that a Shia prevented the one from hunting the other is odd enough, it is odder still to learn of that very Shia, Husain Quli, defiling a Hindu temple on a brahmin's behalf.

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It isn't clear when the brahmin minstrel Mahesh Das joined the imperial court, but he soon became a great favourite of Akbar's. Of the vast number of warlords and officials, feudatory chiefs and zamindars who thronged Akbar's court and fell in and out of his favour, Mahesh Das is one of the very few who never – not once – attracted an imperial reprimand.

Mahesh Das was a 'bhat': 'a class of men', writes P.P. Sinha in his enjoyable biography of the man, 'whom the Persians call badfarosh, "dealers in encomiums"'.[7] If a man trained to sing the praise of kings is popular with kings, that is no surprise, but Mahesh Das's talents seem to have extended beyond flattery. Even Badauni, who calls him Gadai ('Beggar') Brahmadas and deplores the brahmin's proclivity to 'perpetually . . . praise the Hindus' admits that he was a man of 'considerable . . . capacity and genius'. As for Akbar – the padishah almost ran out of encomiums himself when describing Mahesh Das. He was, said Akbar, 'the first among the matchless ones'; knowledgeable and well spoken, he 'charmed the inner circles' and was the centre of any debate, any 'circumference formed by intellectuals'. Best of all, he was 'an affectionate friend and a companion in holy solitude'.[8]

Whatever it was that so attracted the shahinshah to the bard, their